

Sequence - Study Guide

Follow the order of events, steps, and ideas without confusing sequence with cause.

Learning goal

Identify what happens before, after, first, next, or last - and recognize when one step must happen before another can occur.

What sequence really means

Sequence is about order. A text may give events in time order, steps in a process, or ideas arranged so that one stage prepares for the next. The key question is not always "What appears first on the page?" It is "What is the order described by the text?"

A sequence relationship can be explicit, using words such as before, after, then, once, until, or finally. It can also be implied by conditions. For example, if a code is sent only after a reservation is approved, approval must come first even if the passage discusses the code earlier.

Keep these relationships separate

Relationship	Ask yourself	Example
Sequence	What is the order?	The sample is chilled, labeled, and then delivered.
Required order	What must happen before the next step is possible?	A reservation must be approved before a pickup code works.
Cause and effect	Why did something happen?	The storm closed the trail because water covered the bridge.

Question language to recognize

- Which event occurs immediately after ____?
- What happens before ____?

- Which step must be completed before ____ can occur?
- Which event happens last in the process described?

A reliable 3-step method

- 1 Find the target event or step named in the question.
- 2 Mark the event immediately before it and the event immediately after it. Use condition words such as once, until, only after, and before.
- 3 Choose the option that matches the requested position. Reject an option that is a real event but occurs at the wrong time.

Fast scratch note

Write only three labels: BEFORE -> TARGET -> AFTER. This prevents a true but misplaced detail from pulling you away from the question.

Worked example

Example

Before volunteers can use the community kitchen, they complete a safety form. Once the form is approved, the coordinator sends a door code. Volunteers then reserve an available work station. At the end of the session, they record any supplies that need replacing.

1. Which step must occur before the coordinator sends a door code?

- A. Reserve a work station
- B. Record missing supplies
- C. Have the safety form approved
- D. Use the kitchen

Answer: C

The passage says the coordinator sends the code once the form is approved. "Once" makes approval a required earlier step.

Common traps

- A real event in the passage, but not in the position the question asks for.

- A nearby event that happens before the target but is not the required step.
- An invented step that sounds sensible in real life but is not described.
- Treating sequence as cause. Something can happen earlier without causing the later event.

Quick check

Mini text	A lab team labels each water bottle at the collection site. Back at the lab, the bottles are cooled. The team measures acidity the next morning and uploads the readings after the measurements are checked.
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1. What happens immediately before the readings are uploaded?

- A. The bottles are labeled
- B. The bottles are cooled
- C. The acidity is measured
- D. The measurements are checked

Answer: D. Uploading follows the check of the measurements.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: You choose an event that is true, but not the one immediately before or after the target.

Try: Anchor the target event first, then build a three-step timeline:
BEFORE → TARGET → AFTER.

2

If: You explain why something happened instead of when it happened.

Try: Separate order from cause. Sequence asks where an event sits in time, not what caused it.

3

If: You miss words such as before, after, until, once, or only then.

Try: Mark time and condition signals before comparing answer choices.

30-second reset

Before the next sequence question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.